

Take Full Responsibility: How to Model, Featuring Karen Hilton

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Famous psychologist Albert Bandura studied modeling behaviors and found that we adopt the same types of actions that we observe and see modeled in others. So it becomes critical that the behaviors we're modeling are actually behaviors we want our team members to replicate.

One key component of modeling is assessment. Leaders must identify and define the measures of success for ourselves, our team, and our customers. Be clear on the definition of a successful outcome.

Then, ask, 'How is that outcome measured? Is it the right measurement?' If not, what do we need to start, stop, or continue doing to ensure we're successful in assessing the right things.

Coach Summitt said, 'You can't pick and choose the days you feel like being responsible.'

Coach Summitt would follow with this powerful insight, 'If comfort is what you're seeking, then don't aspire. Ambition is uncomfortable by definition.'

I can't state it enough. The best leaders you and I know don't have all the answers. But, they do model the behaviors they want to see in others. In fact, great leaders are quick to acknowledge that they don't have all the answers. They get good at repeating the behavior of trusting and relying on the collective contribution of the team.

Next, a leader who is taking full responsibility must consistently calibrate. That is, measure and gather honest feedback on how they're performing and adjust accordingly. Responsibility evolves.

So as leaders, if we refuse to evolve, we might as well wear a T-shirt that says, 'I'm stuck.'

Ultimately, our success as a leader, a team, or an organization is only as certain as our ability to seek input against what we think or know.

In order to grow, you must accept new responsibilities, no matter how uncertain you may feel or how unprepared you are to deal with them. Unless, of course, you want to do the same thing day after day for the rest of your life.

As you consider your own performance as a leader, ask this, 'Who can serve as a strong source of feedback and accountability? Is your model of success accurate? Does your performance metric stretch you?'

Or are you in a comfort zone?